

Extreme Heat: spot it, cool it, save a life

Extreme heat is the deadliest type of weather in many countries, yet most heat deaths are preventable. The two things that matter most: **cool the body down fast** and **check on people at high risk before they get into trouble**.

CALL EMERGENCY SERVICES NOW

Heat stroke is a life-threatening emergency

Call your local emergency number (911 in the US/Canada, 112 in much of Europe, 999 in the UK) **immediately** if a person is very hot and shows **confusion, slurred speech, fainting, seizures, or loss of consciousness**. While you wait, start cooling them right away (see below). Do not wait to see if they improve.

Know the two stages

HEAT EXHAUSTION — ACT NOW

What you may see

- Heavy sweating
- Cool, pale, clammy skin
- Fast, weak pulse
- Nausea, vomiting
- Muscle cramps
- Tiredness, weakness, dizziness, headache
- Fainting

What to do

- Move to a cool place (shade or air conditioning)
- Loosen clothing
- Sip cool water
- Apply cool, wet cloths or take a cool bath

Get medical help if the person is vomiting, symptoms get worse, or symptoms last longer than 1 hour.

HEAT STROKE — EMERGENCY

What you may see

- Body temperature of 103°F (39.4°C) or higher
- Hot, red skin that is dry *or* damp
- Fast, strong pulse
- Confusion, slurred speech
- Throbbing headache, dizziness
- Losing consciousness

What to do

- **Call emergency services immediately**
- Move the person somewhere cool
- Lower their temperature with cool cloths or a cool bath
- **Do not give them anything to drink** if they are confused or unconscious

Who is most at risk

Heat does not affect everyone equally. Check on these people often during a heat wave:

- Adults aged 65 and older
- Babies and young children
- People with chronic conditions such as heart disease, high blood pressure, diabetes, kidney disease, or mental illness
- People taking certain medications (some affect the body's ability to stay cool — ask a pharmacist if unsure)
- Outdoor workers and athletes
- People who live alone or without air conditioning
- People who are pregnant

PREVENTION

Stay ahead of the heat

- **Drink water** regularly — don't wait until you feel thirsty. (If a doctor limits your fluids, ask them how much to drink in heat.)
- **Stay cool** — spend time in air conditioning. If your home is hot, go to a public cooling center, library, or shopping mall.
- **Avoid the hottest hours** — limit strenuous activity to early morning or evening.
- **Dress light** — wear lightweight, loose, light-colored clothing.
- **Take it easy** — rest often in the shade and pace outdoor work.

NEVER LEAVE ANYONE IN A PARKED CAR

The temperature inside a parked car can rise about 20°F (11°C) in just 10 minutes, even with a window cracked. **Never leave children, older adults, or pets in a parked vehicle** — not even for a minute.

Be a good neighbor

Most people who die in heat waves are found alone. A simple check-in saves lives:

- Pick 2–3 at-risk neighbors, friends, or relatives and agree to check on each other during heat warnings.
- Call or visit in person twice a day during extreme heat.
- Make sure they have water, a way to stay cool, and a working phone.
- Know the route to the nearest cooling center and offer to go together.

Sources

- U.S. Centers for Disease Control and Prevention (CDC) — *Heat & Health and Warning Signs and Symptoms of Heat-Related Illness*. [cdc.gov/heat-health](https://www.cdc.gov/heat-health)

- U.S. National Weather Service (NWS) — *Heat Safety Tips and Resources*. weather.gov/safety/heat
- World Health Organization (WHO) — *Heat and health* fact sheet. [who.int](https://www.who.int)
- Ready.gov (U.S. Dept. of Homeland Security) — *Extreme Heat*. ready.gov/heat

Guidance summarized from the public-health sources above. Temperature and symptom thresholds follow CDC/NWS guidance; emergency-number examples are general.

This guide is general information, not medical advice, and is not a substitute for professional emergency care or training. In an emergency, always call your local emergency number. When symptoms are severe or you are unsure, treat it as an emergency. Reuse and reprint freely.